

Lately, the only reason we stayed together was how tedious the thought of leaving it was.

The headache would attack me the moment I remembered: Ruben had become a part of my life that could only be described as inevitable. Impossible to avoid or evade. And he looked like he was trying. But the quantum equivalent of “Packing your bags” also includes condemning yourself eternally to a devastating loneliness, to a devastating emptiness. They both occupy the same place at the same time, and if I choose one I am stuck with both. Alive and dead at the same time like a cat in a box.

Like a million stars were exploding in my chest at the same time, that's how I felt when I thought about it. And look, I've felt horrible things. I have seen empires collapse, families break up, children grow old, life slip out of our hands. Time is inevitable. Like this, just like Ruben. Impossible to get around.

I guess it makes me selfish, nothing I ever saw made me suffer as much as the mere idea of being eternally alone.

He started the Bolchen Conjecture. Ruben Bolchen wanted to “write history”, that is, if people like us could do it, of course. Or as if we weren't technically doing it all the time. There should be a warning in the signing form you complete before getting to work here, over the psychological and physical requirements. *Occupational hazards: duality.*

The Bolchen Conjecture is more of a statement with no counterarguments, but as I told him that time, just because there are no counterarguments doesn't mean it's true.

“And why not?” he liked to ask, raising his upturned nose, his thin-framed glasses sliding comically. “If truth is the absence of lies, why can't the Conjecture be true? It doesn't contain any lies.”

“Why not, Ruben. If the absence of lies meant truth we would live in a paradox. The lie is relative to the speaker and the listener, and for the same reason, the truth is too.”

“Because you are mean, that is why you do not accept the Conjecture.” Ruben had never liked it when he mixed philosophy with science. He retreated into some archive, papyrus, parchment, paper, rock, whatever he might have gotten his hands on that trip. And I returned to guard the universe.

If you had asked me before I started my travels, what I expected from all this, I would never have thought of a calm routine composed of infinite observation and introspection. Rather, he would have talked about everything he hoped to know about the universe. The origin of everything, where we are, where we come from, all those important questions. In the first days I even tried to keep a diary, confident that everything I could collect would accompany me as an ascended entity, neither alive nor dead. Different in an indescribable way, (*inevitable*).

But my naivety had not lasted long. Diaries are only useful when time means something. But one day, a thousand years, past, present and future had become indecipherable terms. The

machine sent us wherever we were needed, whenever we were needed, and there was no way to appeal or refuse to continue. All that was left was to be silent and obey.

"But doesn't it seem strange to you?" Ruben had never been opposed to the whole idea of the machine and times. "Why does it send us in this order? What if it's guiding us along a path? To see something, discover something else."

"There is no path, Ruben. The machine sends situations to fix problems through time. 'Order' is an illusion of ours, in the societies of the future, all the changes that we are going to make to the past have already happened."

"But order is not non-existent. The machine decides based on mathematical criteria. One has always been before two, what if the machine wants to tell us something?"

"The 'Order', if not an illusion, is just the order the machine receives our chores. We solve something, something else happens, we solve it again. It's literally our work, Ruben."

Back in the time of the Ottoman Empire, once we had to solve a drama with the burning of a painting, Ruben elaborated on his conjecture and told it to me while we were spending time in the local market. I looked at the fabrics and he whispered to me in Spanish, receiving strange looks from the locals from time to time.

"It closes everything to you like this, Amanda." He looked me in the eyes and smiled as if we were living again in a single year, full of latent hope.

"I got lost when you started naming letters."

"They are all letters."

"That's it," I laughed helplessly, his irritated expression exceeding the quantifiable limits on my scale of amusement.

It was a fairly simple treatise, once it was put into coherent words, beyond the madness and incoherences of the sleep-deprived Ruben. The machine was programmed to choose the most urgent cases, but the reason behind the choices, the urgency criterion, was defined as "Universal abstractions and containment of events." The conditions for choosing priority were two: initial present is the last priority, and the university abstractions and the containment of events are the first.

If that was the ulterior motive, Ruben explained, the greatest abstraction would consist of the beginning or the end. That, one of those days, they would end up in one of those two extremes: so far into the future that the universe would be an abysmal and inhospitable mass, (any light and sign of life too far from the others to be visible, any limit or space surpassed, nothing but darkness and the total absence of anything), or so far in the past that the universe would still have to emerge, (and that prospect gave him chills because, wasn't it exciting and terrifying to see where they came from? Would I even see it, or would it vanish with the rest of the known universe?).

The machine also had effects on them, because of the way it related to knowledge. That was a detail that Ruben couldn't explain. A slight doubt that changed everything, an exponent in the numbers.

We were in Antarctica, I can't remember why. Ruben was rubbing his gloved hands over the campfire, his notebook and glasses next to him. He looked haggard, with dark eyes deepened by dark circles and continuous tremors running through his arms and legs. He was bad at the cold, (but something told me that the fear at the bottom of his gaze was more).

But he spoke, as he always did.

"The human brain is his own universe. The body is a galaxy. We are an astronomical system compressed into a pocket size for the sky."

I raised my eyebrows: "I thought you didn't like philosophy."

"I don't."

"But you just said something quite philosophical."

"Your point being?"

I commented, a thought escaped my lips: "If the brain is a universe, according to your conjecture, what is abstraction for humans?"

Today, (one of the few measures of time I allow myself to conserve, for the sake of my health), Ruben checked the machine, looked me in the eyes and massaged his temples.

"What's happening? What destiny do we have?"

"Our present. The beginning."

I raised my eyebrows: "And the work?"

"To forget."

Abstraction was inevitable. Like time, like Ruben and like everything.